BUSINESS OPERATIONS

Building a Digital HQ

1.0 Executive Summary

A growing real estate investment firm faced significant operational friction. The absence of a centralized system led to disorganized files, fragmented communication, and a non-professional image (e.g., using @gmail.com addresses), creating unacceptable business risks.

This case study shows I designed and deployed a cost-effective "Digital HQ" using Google Workspace. This involved establishing a professional domain, architecting an intuitive file system to serve as the Single Source of Truth (SSOT), implementing role-based security, and creating empowering SOPs. The project eliminated critical risks, reduced administrative waste by over 95%, and established a scalable foundation for future growth. The firm now operates with enhanced professionalism, security, and efficiency.

2.0 Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

Metric	Before Solution	After Solution	Improvement
Time to Retrieve Document	~50+ Minutes	< 1 Minute	**>98% Reduction**
Rework from Incorrect Versions	High Risk (Hours/Days)	Eliminated	**100% Risk Mitigation**
System Management	Consultant Dependent	Self-Sufficient	**Empowered Team**

3.0 Lean Six Sigma Analysis: Value Stream Mapping

A Value Stream Map (VSM) of the "before" state revealed significant non-value-added activities (Waste) in the process of finding a project document. The primary wastes identified were **Waiting**, **Defects** (using wrong files), and **Motion** (searching multiple locations).

BEFORE: Disjointed Workflow

1. Employee Needs Doc
   ↓
2. ! Searches Email (Waste: 15min)
   ↓
3. ! Asks Coworker (Waste: 25min)
   ↓
4. ✗ **Rework Required (RISK: Hours-Days)**

AFTER: Optimized Workflow

1. Employee Needs Doc
   ↓
2. Navigates to Google Drive
   ↓
3. Finds Correct File Instantly
   ↓
4. ✓ **Proceeds with Confidence**

4.0 Deliverable: Information Architecture

A key deliverable was the design of a scalable and intuitive information architecture. This structure separates company administration from project operations, incorporates role-based access controls, and provides a standardized template for all new projects to ensure consistency.

Part 1: Company-Wide Directory

```
📁 [Your Company Name]
  📁 Investment_Properties [All Users]
    📁 [Template] Project_Folder
    📁 2020_Katy_Project
    📁 2024_Brenham_Project
    📁 2025_Pasadena_Project
    📁 2022_Canyon_Lake_Project
  📁 Operations [All Users]
    📁 SOPs
    📁 Templates
    📁 Workflows
  📁 Company_Admin [Restricted]
    📁 Branding
    📁 Legal
    📁 Financial
  📁 Users [Private]
    📁 Jonathan_Rauckhorst
    📁 Jane_Smith
```

Part 2: Project Folder Template

```
📁 [YYYY_Project_Name]
  📁 01_Project_Management
  📁 02_Design
  📁 03_Estimates
  📁 04_Contracts_And_Legal
  📁 05_Financials
  📁 06_Permits_And_Inspections
  📁 07_Photos_And_Media
    📁 Before_Renovation
    📁 After_Renovation
  📁 08_Rental_Data
  📁 _Archive
```

Statement of Work (SOW)

Prepared for: [Client Company Name]
Prepared by: Jonathan Rauckhorst, Operations Consultant
Date: July 17, 2025

Project: Foundational Operations & Digital HQ Setup

1. Project Overview & Objectives

This project will remediate operational inefficiencies by establishing a centralized Digital HQ. Key objectives include deploying Google Workspace for professional identity, implementing a secure and scalable file management system (SSOT), defining role-based access controls, and delivering documentation to ensure client self-sufficiency.

2. Scope of Services & Deliverables

Phase	Description	Key Deliverables
Phase 1: Foundation	Procure domain, set up Google Workspace, configure core services, and establish user roles.	1. Secured Domain Name. 2. Active Google Workspace with professional emails. 3. Defined User Roles (Admin, Member).
Phase 2: Architecture	Build out the approved information architecture and apply role-based permissions.	1. Approved Folder Structure built in Google Drive. 2. Role-Based Permissions implemented.
Phase 3: Empowerment	Develop a user-friendly SOP and train the client on usage and maintenance.	1. Comprehensive SOP & User Guide. 2. Live Training Session (recorded). 3. 30 days of post-launch email support.

3. Out of Scope

- Website design or development.
- Procurement or management of any software beyond Google Workspace.
- Data entry or migration of existing unorganized files.
- Ongoing IT helpdesk support beyond the specified 30-day period.

4. Assumptions

- Client will provide timely access to necessary accounts and information.
- Key stakeholders will be available for scheduled meetings and training.
- Decisions and feedback will be provided within 2 business days of request.

5. Project Investment

A detailed quote will be provided upon request. Pricing is typically structured as a fixed fee for the total project scope.

6. Acceptance Criteria

This project will be considered complete upon the client's written confirmation (email sufficient) that all deliverables outlined in Section 2 have been provided and the training session has been concluded.

Sample: Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)

SOP: Digital File Management

SOP ID:	OPS-001
Version:	1.0
Effective Date:	July 17, 2025
Owner:	Operations Manager

1. Purpose & Scope

This document outlines the standard procedure for creating, naming, storing, and archiving all digital files within the company's Google Drive. Adherence to this SOP is mandatory for all employees to ensure information integrity and operational efficiency.

2. Roles & Responsibilities

- **All Users:** Responsible for adhering to the file naming convention and storing files in their correct locations.
- **Admin Users (Owner, Assistant):** Responsible for creating new top-level project folders, managing user access, and performing periodic audits.

3. The Golden Rules of Filing

1. **Always Save to the Cloud.** Never save a final work document only to your computer's desktop. All work must be saved in the appropriate Google Drive folder.
2. **Use the Project Template.** For every new investment property, an Admin User must duplicate the "[Template] Project_Folder" and rename it according to the standard: `YYYY_Project_Name`.
3. **Follow the Naming Convention.** Proper naming is critical for search and version control.

   `Format: YYYY-MM-DD_Description_vX.X.ext`

   - **YYYY-MM-DD:** The date the file was created or significantly revised.
   - **Description:** A clear, concise description (e.g., `Katy-Plumbing-Contract`).
   - **vX.X:** The version number (e.g., `v1.0`, `v1.1`, `v2.0`).
   - **Example:** `2025-07-17_Katy-Plumbing-Contract_v1.0.pdf`
4. **Manage Versions Correctly.**
   - When updating a file, do not overwrite the old one.
   - **Step 1:** Move the previous version (e.g., `..._v1.0.pdf`) into the `_Archive` folder within that project.
   - **Step 2:** Save the new file with the incremented version number (e.g., `..._v1.1.pdf`) in the correct working directory.
   - This ensures a complete history is preserved while keeping the working directory clean.